

TREMITI ISLANDS

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CAP. 1 — INTRO: LUCIO AND THE DINGHY

The first time Lucio Dalla stepped onto my dinghy was 1979.

He arrived at the port of San Domino with a bag and a straw hat. No entourage, no assistant, nobody recognising him straight away — or at least that's how he acted. He asked if I'd take him to see the caves. I said yes. We set off.

My name is Tonino. Seventy-four years old. Born here, grew up here, lived here. I started as a boatman at seventeen with my father, and I've never stopped.

Lucio came back every year. Sometimes with other musicians — people I didn't know, he'd introduce them and I'd nod. Sometimes alone. Always with me.

The last time he came, he had the same kind of hat as in 1979. I don't know if it was the same one. I asked him if he kept coming back because the islands were beautiful. He said: no. I come back because you don't ask questions.

CAP. 2 — THE ISLANDS: WHAT THEY ARE AND HOW TO GET THERE

The Tremiti Islands are five.

San Domino, the largest — pine forest, caves, beaches. San Nicola, the historic one — the abbey, the castle, the monks. Capraia, uninhabited. Cretaccio, a rock. La Vecchia, another rock.

You get there by ferry from Vieste, Peschici, Rodi Garganico, Manfredonia, Termoli. In summer there are constant crossings — roughly every hour. In winter two crossings a week.

Three hundred inhabitants in winter. Three hundred thousand visitors in summer. You understand how life changes here.

In winter the islands are quiet. The wind hums through the pines. The ferry brings supplies and post. Everyone knows everyone. I know every person who lives here — and I know their stories, and their fathers' stories.

CAP. 3 — SAN DOMINO: THE FOREST AND THE SEA

San Domino is the island of beauty.

An Aleppo pine forest that covers almost the whole island — scent of resin, shade even in summer, narrow paths between the roots.

And then the sea. A sea that Lucio looked for every time. He'd tell me: Tonino, the water here has a colour I haven't seen anywhere else. And he was right.

The seabed around the islands is pale rock and posidonia — that sea plant that makes the water green. A few metres from shore, in certain spots, the water changes colour three times. Emerald green near the shore. Turquoise in the middle. Deep blue where the bottom drops.

Cala delle Arene is the main beach on San Domino. Sand mixed with posidonia. It fills up in summer. But there are coves only reachable by boat — Cala delle Roselle, Cala dello Spido — where tourism doesn't reach. Those ones, I know.

CAP. 4 — THE CAVES: THE TRIP WITH LUCIO

The cave trip was the ritual.

Every time Lucio came, before anything else, the cave trip. Early morning, when the sea was flat and the light entered low on the water.

The Grotta delle Viole is the most famous. It's called that because the walls reflect the water's light and turn violet. It's not a special effect — it's physics. The light filtering up through the water colours the rock walls.

The first time Lucio saw it he went silent. He said nothing for maybe two minutes. Then he said: Tonino, in here I hear songs.

I didn't know if he meant something concrete or something metaphorical. With him you never could tell. But I understood what he meant — some places have a resonance. I don't know what it's called in music. I know you feel it.

The Grotta del Bue Marino is the largest. You enter with the dinghy. Inside it's ten metres high, with stalactites hanging from the ceiling. The bue marino — monk seals — lived

here until the 1970s. Then they disappeared. The occasional sighting still, but rare.

CAP. 5 — SAN NICOLA: THE ISLAND OF MONKS

San Nicola is the island of history.

No hotels. No restaurants. No beaches. There's a dock, a staircase, a medieval castle, and a tenth-century Benedictine abbey.

The Abbey of Santa Maria is built on top of a pagan Greek temple. Built on top — meaning the temple's foundations are the abbey's foundations. The monks didn't clear away what was there. They built over it.

Inside the abbey there's a twelfth-century mosaic floor. Animals, geometric patterns, symbols. A thousand years of footsteps — and it's all still visible.

The monks are still there. Just a few — two or three at certain times. They live in the abbey, open the church to visitors. Sometimes I see them when I pass with the dinghy — black figures on the white dock. Same scene as eight hundred years ago.

CAP. 6 — EXILE: PARADISE AND PRISON

Something Lucio knew about and had asked me to tell him.

The Tremiti were a prison.

The Bourbons, in the nineteenth century, sent political prisoners here. The island was perfect — isolated, hard to reach, impossible to escape from. The prisoners lived in the San Nicola abbey — the same walls as the monks, but in very different conditions.

Then Fascism revived the practice. The nineteen thirties — regime opponents sent here into internal exile. Intellectuals, politicians, antifascists. They lived on the island, not in a cell — they could move around, but they couldn't leave.

Lucio said to me once: think how strange it was. They send you to serve your sentence in the most beautiful place in the world. And the beauty makes it even worse — because you can see everything except the one thing you want.

I sat with that thought for a while. He was right, as always.

CAP. 7 — LIFE ON THE ISLAND IN WINTER

In summer the Tremiti are what you see in the photos.

In winter they're what I know.

November. The ferry runs twice a week. If the sea is rough, it doesn't run. It might stay away three, four days. Nothing arrives — no supplies, no post, no people.

On those days the island is truly isolated. The way it always was. You make do with what you have. You help each other. You eat together.

The winter sea around the islands is a different sea. Not the summer turquoise — dark green, almost black on tramontana days. The waves push into the caves and make a sound you can hear half a kilometre away.

I still go out. Not every day. But when the weather allows. I circle the islands, check the boats, watch. In seventy years at sea I never grow tired of watching.

CAP. 8 — WHAT TO DO AND HOW TO GET THERE

Most important: book the ferry in advance.

In summer the crossings fill up. It's not unusual to find everything sold out if you wait until the day before. Book at least a week ahead, two if you're coming in August.

To see the caves: hire a dinghy or take a guided boat tour. The tours leave from San Domino harbour every morning. They last three to four hours. They include all the main caves. Ask the boatman to stop inside the Grotta delle Viole and switch off the engine. Listen.

For San Nicola: go by ferry or private boat. The abbey visit takes an hour. It's free. The monks accept donations.

If you can, stay a night. There are small guesthouses on San Domino. In the evening, when the ferry has gone and the day visitors have left, the islands become quiet again. It's a different place.

CAP. 9 — WHAT TO EAT ON THE TREMITI

Lobster.

The waters around the Tremiti are protected — National Park, controlled fishing. The result is that the seabed is still rich. Lobster, sea urchins, octopus, grouper. Fish that in many other parts of the Mediterranean has almost disappeared.

The restaurants on San Domino cook what the locals catch. It's not a slogan — it's practical reality. There's no fish market. No fish comes from outside. You cook what you bring in.

Grilled lobster with olive oil — simple, without sauces, without fuss. Fresh fish needs nothing. Whoever adds too much doesn't trust the fish.

Lucio always had the lobster. Every time. With white wine. And he'd say: Tonino, this is the best thing there is. I'd answer: yes, but don't tell your cook.

CAP. 10 — CAPRAIA AND CRETACCIO: THE ISLANDS NOBODY VISITS

The Tremiti Islands are five — but everyone only talks about two.

Everyone knows San Domino and San Nicola. Capraia is known to those who come often. Cretaccio and La Vecchia are known to almost nobody — and that's exactly why they deserve a mention.

Capraia is uninhabited. Rock and Mediterranean scrub. No port, no mooring. You circle it by dinghy. In summer the seabirds nest there — shearwaters, gulls, the odd cormorant. It's an island that exists for itself, not for those who visit.

Cretaccio is a lump of red clay — the name comes from "creta," clay. Depending on the light it looks orange, bordeaux, almost violet. From a dinghy, a few metres away, it's one of the strangest things you can see in this sea.

CAP. 11 — THE MARINE PARK: WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

The waters around the Tremiti are protected.

Marine Protected Area since 1989 — one of the first in Italy. This means fishing is regulated, certain zones are off-limits, the seabed has had decades to recover.

The result shows underwater. Meadows of *posidonia oceanica* — the sea plant that oxygenates the Mediterranean — full of grouper, white bream, gilt-head bream. Lobster in the cracks of the rock. In certain spots the seabed is so alive it seems impossible it still exists in the twenty-first century Mediterranean.

Divers say the Tremiti are among the best diving sites in the Adriatic. I don't dive. But I see it from above — the way the water changes colour, the fish you can see from the dinghy. What's down there I can guess from what I see on the surface.

CAP. 12 — THE NIGHT SKY AT THE TREMITI

Those who sleep at the Tremiti know something that day-trippers don't.

The night sky here is something else entirely.

There's no artificial light around — the sea is dark, the mainland shores are far away. In summer, with no moon, the Milky Way is visible to the naked eye. Not as a vague smear — as a dense, defined band cutting right across the sky.

Lucio knew this. He'd go out onto the jetty at night. He'd sit there an hour, sometimes two. He didn't speak. I don't know if he was watching the sky or the sea. Maybe both together.

If you come to the Tremiti, stay one night. Wait for the five o'clock ferry to leave, for the day-trippers to disappear. Then go outside at eleven. Look up.

CAP. 13 — THE PORT OF SAN DOMINO: WHERE LIFE TURNS

Everything that happens at the Tremiti passes through the port of San Domino.

The ferries arrive there. The supplies arrive there. The fish leaves from there. The stories are told there — on the jetty, sitting on the bollards, with a coffee in hand.

I've spent half my life at that port. I've seen tourists arrive, journalists, politicians, directors. I've seen Lucio arrive with his bag and his straw hat. I've seen coffins leave — in winter, when someone dies on the island, the ferry takes them away too.

The port is the beating heart. When it goes still — when the sea is rough and nobody arrives — the island holds its breath. When the ferry returns, it starts breathing again.

CAP. 14 — THE SEASONS: HOW THE TREMITI CHANGE

The Tremiti in August and the Tremiti in December are two different islands.

August: packed beaches, ferries every hour, restaurants booked days ahead, dinghies everywhere. The island is alive, noisy, beautiful. But it's not just yours.

December: the ferry twice a week. Three hundred inhabitants. One bar open. The wind driving high waves into the caves. Silence.

Both are real. I prefer the December one — but I don't tell the tourists that, or they all come and it stops working. I'm telling you because you're already here. Or at least, almost.

CAP. 15 — HISTORY: ROMANS, BENEDICTINES, PRISONERS

The Tremiti have a long history.

The Romans were already sending people here into exile long before the Bourbons. Julia, niece of Augustus, was exiled here in 8 AD. The same place, the same waves, the same impossibility of leaving.

The Benedictines arrived in the eleventh century. They built the Abbey of Santa Maria on San Nicola — the one that still stands today. They managed the islands for centuries, farming, fishing, copying manuscripts. Then the pirates, then the prisoners, then the

tourists.

Tonino — that is, me — I'm the last link in this chain. A boatman like my father, like my grandfather. I didn't build abbeys or ferry prisoners. I took people to see the caves. It's less epic. But it's part of the same story.

CAP. 16 — FISHING: LOBSTERS AND RULES

The lobsters of the Tremiti are famous.

Not by chance — the protected waters have let the populations grow back. Lobsters live in the crevices of the rock, at varying depths. The fishermen catch them with lobster pots — net traps on the seabed. Not many. What's needed, no more.

The marine park regulates fishing. Not everything can be taken, not all year, not everywhere. The fishermen sometimes complain — understandably, it's their livelihood. But without the rules, the sea empties out. I've seen it happen elsewhere. Here it hasn't happened because the rules exist.

Sea urchins are another treasure. Raw, with a squeeze of lemon. Lucio used to eat them sitting on the jetty — bought straight from the fisherman, no plate, no fork. That was his favourite lunch.

CAP. 17 — THE NIGHT: STARS AND DARK SEA

Those who sleep at the Tremiti know something that day-trippers don't.

At night the sea turns phosphorescent.

At certain times of year, in certain spots along the coast, the waves break with a blue light. It's not an illusion — they're bioluminescent microorganisms. Phytoplankton reacting to movement. From the dinghy, at night, you can see the glowing trails in the water.

Lucio knew about this. One night he asked me to go out late — past midnight. We circled the island in silence, engine barely ticking. The water shimmered blue. He said nothing. The next morning he said: Tonino, last night I felt something I can't put into music. Maybe that's for the best.

CAP. 18 — WHAT TO BRING AND WHAT NOT TO DO

The Tremiti require a little care.

First of all: travel light. There are no large supermarkets on the island. There are no 24-hour pharmacies. There are no petrol stations for dinghies around every corner. Bring

what you need — sunscreen, medication, cash.

Respect for the marine park is both mandatory and right. Don't collect anything from the seabed. Don't anchor where it's not permitted — posidonia meadows are easily destroyed. Don't take away shells, coral, stones. It's not romantic — it's theft.

And one more thing: don't only come in August. June is wonderful — warm, the water already clear, fewer people. September is even better. Summer lasts until October, out here. And the island gets to breathe again.

CAP. 19 — THE ABBEY OF SANTA MARIA: A THOUSAND YEARS OF STONE

The Abbey of Santa Maria on San Nicola is a thousand years old.

It was built by the Benedictines in the eleventh century. It's not large — a church of human proportions, with a simple Romanesque facade and a bell tower visible from far out at sea. I've counted seeing it ten thousand times, passing by in the dinghy. It never tires me.

Inside: the twelfth-century mosaic floor. Animals, geometric shapes, symbols. A thousand years of footsteps on top — and you can still see it. You can tell those mosaics were made to last, not to dazzle. There's a difference.

The monks who still live there are few. They open the church to visitors. They accept donations. They don't talk much — or maybe they talk a lot, but at a different pace. When I pass with the dinghy and see them on the jetty, in black, still, I think they look at the sea the way I do. With respect and habit together.

CAP. 20 — NOSTALGIA: THE TREMITI INSIDE PEOPLE

The Tremiti do a strange thing to people.

Those who come once, come back.

Not everyone — but a high percentage of those who visit stay connected. I've watched it for decades. Families who come back every summer. Couples who met here and still come. Elderly people who come alone, the way they did when they were young.

Lucio was the extreme case — thirty years without missing one. But he wasn't the only one. I have regular customers — some I call by name, I know the children who were little and are now grown.

I can't explain it with logic. It's not just the beautiful sea — beautiful sea is everywhere. It's not just the calm — there are calmer places. It's something to do with limits. You're on

an island. You can't go further. And paradoxically you feel more free.

CAP. 21 — CLOSING: TONINO SAYS GOODBYE

Lucio died in 2012.

That summer nobody came to the port with a straw hat. I waited — not consciously, but I waited. Then I understood he wouldn't be coming back.

That dinghy is still the same — I've repaired it, replaced the engine, but it's the same boat. Sometimes when I go out early in the morning and pass in front of the Grotta delle Viole, I still hear his voice. Tonino, in here I hear songs.

These islands do this. They get inside people. Those who come once, come back. Those who come back enough times, can never quite leave.

Come. Get a boat. Go into the caves. Switch the engine off and listen.

The islands have something to say. You just have to be still long enough to hear it.

This headland has other faces.

The trabucchi coast at sunset, the coves of Vieste reachable only from the sea, the archangel's cave twelve degrees all year round, the inland villages that no sea navigator can find. Each one has someone who tells its story. Someone who never left.

The Gargano doesn't end here.